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Brand Strength's Influence on Volunteers' Retention and Support Intentions

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ABSTRACT

We developed and tested a conceptual model's influence on a sample of active volunteers' retention intentions and on their intentions to support their organizations in other ways (e.g. donations). Approximately 200 nonprofit organizations were contacted to participate in this study by asking their volunteers to complete our online survey. This resulted in over 600 completed questionnaires. Data were analyzed using PLS-SEM techniques. We examined the influence of brand strength on six outcome variables (1-year retention intentions, 5-year retention intentions, donation intentions, bequest intentions, volunteer recruitment intentions, and word-of-mouth intentions). Brand strength's effects on all the outcome variables were significant. The influence of brand strength on bequest and donation intentions was partially mediated through its influence on organizational transparency. Additionally, the influence of seven proposed moderators (organizational transparency, volunteer morale, organizational socialization, training program quality, organizational trust, confidence in leadership, organizational pride, and value congruence) was also tested, with mixed results.

KEYWORDS

Bequest intentions; brand strength; donation intentions; nonprofit brand; transparency; volunteer retention

Introduction

Because of the potential benefits, there is a growing interest in marketing and branding among nonprofit managers (Apaydın, 2011). For example, Boenigk and Becker (2016) argue that effective brand strategies can have a favorable influence on donation intentions and volunteer involvement. Napoli (2006) found that most successful nonprofit organizations tended to be brand oriented. Unfortunately, there is comparatively little research on the influence of brand-related constructs on nonprofit outcome variables (Liu et al., 2015).

To address this lack on research, Liu et al. (2015) investigated the benefits of a nonprofit brand management orientation and found a positive influence of having a brand orientation on staff attachment to the nonprofit brand. On another nonprofit brand topic, Curran et al. (2016) investigated the influence of brand heritage on volunteers' satisfaction with management. They found

that volunteer engagement mediates the influence of brand heritage on volunteers' satisfaction with management. Another study found that charity brand personality and donors' satisfaction mediated the influence of charity brand experience on donation intentions (Ali et al., 2022).

Laidler-Kylander et al. (2004) argued that there is a strong need for more research on the role of nonprofit brand constructs in retaining volunteers. Volunteer retention is an important issue for many nonprofit organizations (Garner & Garner, 2011; Netting et al., 2005). A high volunteer turnover rate can place additional pressure on volunteer recruitment demands and also negatively influence volunteer morale and service delivery (Bidee et al., 2013; Cho et al., 2020; Wong et al., 2011). Hager and Brudney (2004) reported that about 40% of volunteers discontinue their service due to poor volunteer management practices. While prior studies on volunteers' motivations have added to our understanding their behavior (Bang et al., 2012; Hallmann & Harms, 2012; Li & Wu, 2018), examining the influence of other factors on volunteer retention would be valuable (Cho et al., 2020). In the investigation reported in this paper, we are interested in the influences of constructs in our conceptual model on active volunteers. In this investigation, we are interested in exploring influences on volunteers' retention intentions and on volunteers' intentions to support their organizations in other ways.

The investigation reported in this paper adds to our knowledge in the literature gap areas of nonprofit branding and volunteer retention. In helping to fill these gaps, we examine the influence of brand strength on volunteer retention intentions. However, since volunteers may support their organizations in additional ways, we include other support intentions (donations, bequests, recruiting volunteers, and word-of-mouth referrals) as outcome variables. Our investigation includes the examination of a potential mediator (organizational transparency) and moderators that may interact with brand strength's influence on our proposed volunteer behavioral intentions. The moderators included in our study are volunteer morale, organizational socialization, training program quality, organizational trust, confidence in leadership, organizational pride, and value congruence.

The scientific and practical relevance of this study is that it adds to our knowledge on construct relationships that influence volunteers' retention intentions and intentions to support their organizations in additional ways. Researchers can use our discoveries to further our understanding of these phenomena. Managers can use our discoveries to inform their managerial practices to more effectively retain their volunteers and deepen their commitment.

Literature review

To achieve the aims of this study, the conceptual model depicted in [Figure 1](#) was evaluated.

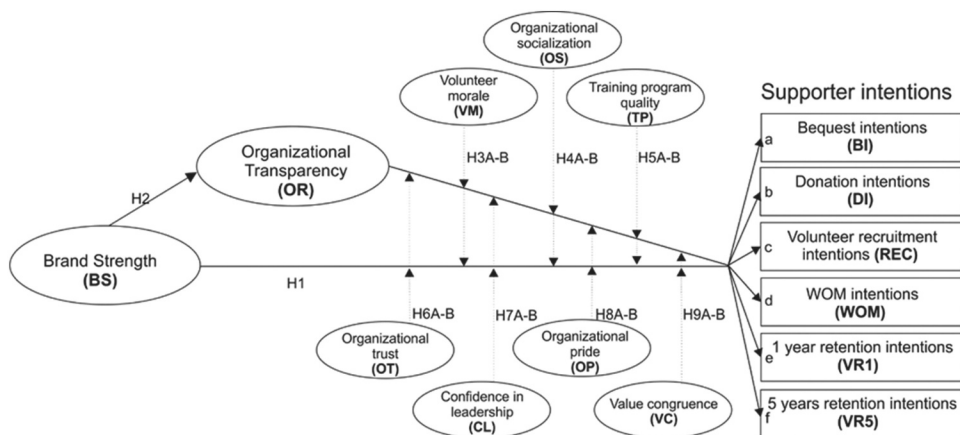


Figure 1. Conceptual model.

Outcomes – supporter intentions

Outcomes, supporter intentions, are the desired effects or consequents presented in our conceptual model. In this study, our supporters are active volunteers. In practice, nonprofit organizations use marketing tactics to attain desired benefits or outcomes such as support from individuals. They seek support from individuals in a variety of ways like donating, volunteering, word-of-mouth referrals, and so forth (Peloza & Hassay, 2007). In Figure 1, we present a conceptual model having six outcome intentions. As our model is relatively complex and as the prior literature is limited, we shall consider our outcomes collectively when developing our hypotheses, but we shall test the model's influence on our outcomes individually.

The outcomes in our conceptual model include volunteer retention intentions, referring to volunteers' plans to continue their volunteer service (Harp et al., 2017). It is useful to differentiate retention intentions in the near term and longer term. Hence, we include retention intentions for the next year (VR1) and for the next five years (VR5).

Wymer and Rundle-Thiele (2016) recommend that researchers include multiple outcomes in their conceptual models. This enables a richer understanding of the dynamic influences at play. Furthermore, volunteers can manifest their support in a variety of ways. Some volunteers may choose to donate their time as volunteers instead of donating their money as donors. Some volunteers may choose to donate both their time and money. Falvo (2018) reported that nearly two-thirds of volunteers also donated money to their organizations. Accordingly, we thought it would be useful to assess volunteers' intentions to provide monetary support to their organizations. Relevant monetary support intentions include donation intentions (DI) and bequest intentions (BI).

Volunteers may also support their organizations in other ways as a manifestation of greater commitment (Nghah et al., 2022). Additional support intentions included in our conceptual model are favorable word-of-mouth referrals (WOM), and intentions to assist the organization in its volunteer recruitment activities (REC).

Brand strength

Marketing's purpose is to help the nonprofit organization acquire and retain support, such as volunteers, donations, and so forth. A brand orientation is a managerial mind-set in which managing the organization as a brand facilitates resource/support acquisition and retention. The brand object or entity that is branded is the nonprofit organization. The brand is a latent psychological construct that refers to the perceptions, associations, and meaning of the organization in the minds of priority audiences (individuals whose engagement and support the organization seeks to acquire and retain) (Wymer, 2013; Wymer & Casidy, 2019). A contribution of this inquiry is that we chose active volunteers as a priority audience and examine brand strength from their perspectives.

The overarching goal of brand management is to make the brand (i.e., a nonprofit organization) a strong brand, ideally the strongest brand among its peer set (Wymer, 2013). A strong brand enjoys benefits not attainable to a weak brand. For example, the Red Cross, a strong brand, gets the preponderance of donations compared to other relief organizations in the aftermath of a natural disaster (Wymer et al., 2016).

Wymer et al. (2016) conceptualized a strong brand as having high levels of its three dimensions: brand familiarity, brand remarkability, and brand attitudes. Brand familiarity refers to the level of knowledge a priority audience has about a brand object, in this context, a nonprofit organization or charity. Brand remarkability refers to the degree to which a brand object (i.e., charity) is perceived by a priority audience (i.e., volunteers) to be extraordinary. Brand attitudes refer to the degree to which a brand (i.e., a charity) is perceived favorably by a priority audience.

Related prior research leads us to believe that brand strength may influence volunteers' retention intentions and other support intentions. Casais and Santos (2018) found that supporters only donated to charities with which they were familiar. The more knowledgeable people are about a charity, the more aware they are of the charity's mission and its good works (Torres-Moraga et al., 2010). The degree to which a charity is well-known can influence individuals' trust in a charity as individuals are more likely to trust a familiar than an unfamiliar charity (Paço et al., 2015; Rim et al., 2016). Bennett and Gabriel (2003) reported that individuals' familiarity with a charity influences their perceptions of the charity's reputation, which, in turn, influences their donation behaviors. Although we make inferences on prior

research on donors to guide our hypothesis development, a contribution of this inquiry is that we extend prior research by examining influences on active volunteers.

Wymer and Casidy (2019) argued that brand familiarity is a predictor of brand attitudes. Bennett (2003) found that individuals' attitudes toward charities influenced their choice of charities for donations. Other research has found a relationship between charity brand attitudes and donation intentions (Smith & McSweeney, 2007; Teah et al., 2014).

Bennett and Gabriel (2003) reported that an excellent charity image was a determinant of donation income. For a priority audience to perceive a charity as having an excellent image, the priority audience must be somewhat familiar with the charity and believe that the charity is exceptional (Werke & Bogale, 2023). When donors are deciding where to donate, the charity that is perceived to be mediocre or no better than average may not be chosen; instead, the charity that is perceived to be outstanding is more likely to be the donor's recipient. This reasoning is consistent with prior research which reports an influence between a charity's reputation and donor giving (Bennett, 2009; Bennett & Ali-Choudhury, 2009; Sargeant & Woodliffe, 2007) and donor perceptions of charity service delivery excellence and giving (Michel & Rieunier, 2012). Although the prior research has focused on reputational influences on donation intentions, we predict that a related dynamic exists between brand strength and all our volunteer support intentions.

H1: Brand strength has a positive influence on volunteer support intentions.

Organizational transparency

Organizational transparency refers to the degree to which individuals perceive a nonprofit organization to share information with its priority audiences to enhance their understanding of the organization's operations and practices, to build trust, and to create accountability (Alhidari et al., 2018). Priority audiences' perceptions of a charity's transparency are influenced by how accessible a charity makes its information, the completeness of the information, and the perceived accuracy of the information (Dethier et al., 2023). Sanzo-Pérez et al. (2017) report that there is little research on nonprofit organizational transparency and its effects. Helmig and Thaler (2010) identify exploratory research on transparency in the context of nonprofit marketing as a critical need.

Furneaux and Wymer (2015) and Wymer et al. (2021) reported that transparency is an important influencer of public trust in a charity. Farwell et al. (2019) argue that accountability and transparency influence the public's trust in a charity. In crowdfunding campaigns, operational transparency or regular updates of progress positively affect donations due to donors' perceptions of effort and trust (Mejia et al., 2019). In the human resource management literature, prior research has reported that

information flow from the organization has a positive influence on employee's trust in their supervisors (Shockley-Zalabak et al., 2000). While the behavioral influences on paid employees may not be identical to those on volunteers, prior human resource research may be useful in developing hypotheses in some instances.

Charity watchdog organizations attempt to protect donors and to encourage charities to adhere to transparency and good stewardship (Stötzer et al., 2023; Szper & Prakash, 2011). It is unclear how widely donors rely on watchdog ratings of charities to target their donations. Charity watchdog ratings are probably more important for lesser-known charities (that is, weak brands) than well-known charities (Stötzer et al., 2023) and when making larger donations which incurs greater potential donor risk.

Prior research on charity transparency is concerned with the construct's influence on donors (Liket & Maas, 2015). Transparency is advocated to provide assurance and to enhance trust to donor audiences (Barber et al., 2022; Bodem-Schrötgens & Becker, 2020; Chu & Luke, 2023). Sanzo-Pérez et al. (2017) argue that transparency become one of the most important dimensions for nonprofit organization, while Harris and Neely (2021) reported that higher level of transparency contributes to higher supporter intentions or future contributions. Organizational transparency may influence volunteers as well. Hence, examining transparency's influence on volunteers represents an additional contribution of this inquiry.

Wymer and Najev Čačija (2023) argue that organizational transparency may not be as important for well-known charities as it is for relatively unknown charities. They argue that charities that are perceived to be strong brands enjoy being well-known (brand familiarity) and have superior reputations (brand remarkability and brand attitudes) and are more likely to be trusted than weak charity brands. Hence, brand strength's influence on supporter outcomes may be at least partially mediated through organizational transparency because of brand strength's influence on audiences' perceptions of organizational transparency.

It is likely that brand strength has a positive influence on volunteers' perceptions of organizational transparency. Strong levels of brand strength indicate that volunteers are familiar with their organizations, have positive attitudes toward their organizations, and believe their organizations are exceptional. Thus, the greater familiarity combines with a halo effect from high levels of brand attitudes and brand remarkability would likely exert a positive influence on perceived organizational transparency. From a practical viewpoint, organizations must communicate with priority audiences to increase brand familiarity. Organizational communication should also enhance perceived organizational transparency.

Although we bundle our outcome variables collectively as supporter intentions, it is likely that our constructs will differentially influence our six

outcome variables. Generally, there is an insufficient body of prior research to guide precise hypothesis predictions of the model's constructs on each individual outcome variable. One contribution of this research is that we shall learn more about the differential influences on our outcome variables. For example, given the prior research on transparency and trust and donations, it may be that transparency has a greater influence on our donation intentions than on other outcome variables. Donation and bequest intentions, for example, have a degree of donor risk that is distinct. The differential influence on our outcome variables is, in effect, somewhat exploratory.

H2: The influence of brand strength on volunteer support intentions is partially mediated through organizational transparency.

Moderation effects

To further add to our knowledge of the influence of brand strength and organizational transparency on supporter outcomes, we sought to identify and test potential moderators of these relationships. We selected potential moderators that we believe could affect the influence of brand strength on our outcome variables. We also selected potential moderators that are typically present in the volunteering experience.

Volunteer morale. Volunteer morale refers to degree to which volunteers have positive attitudes toward their organization, its leadership, and its staff/volunteers (Arunchand & Ramanathan, 2013; Sania et al., 2015). There is deficit of research on volunteer morale, so we rely on prior research on employee morale to provide guidance. Overall, there seems to be a relationship between employee morale, employee attitudes, motivation, satisfaction, and performance (Milligan, 2006). Extending prior research on employee behavior to volunteer behavioral intentions represents a potential contribution of this inquiry.

Rostina et al. (2023) found that employee enthusiasm has a positive influence on productivity. Conversely, Shaban et al. (2017) found that low employee morale negatively influenced performance. Prior research reports that corporate reputation has a positive influence on employee commitment (Almeida & Coelho, 2019). Gray and Balmer (1998) argue that corporate reputation and morale interact and influence employee performance. We argue that brand strength has a similar effect as organizational reputation and that volunteers' morale is likely influenced by brand strength. Drawing inferences from prior human resource research, volunteers' morale will likely interact with brand strength's influence on their support intentions.

H3a: Volunteer morale moderates brand strength's influence on supporter intentions.

With respect to organizational transparency, Ingram (2009) found that an employer's transparency with respect to hiring and promotions had a positive influence on employee morale. Kwon and Park (2019) argue that organizational transparency can be part of a strategy to improve public sector employee morale. Nabors (2019) found that managerial transparency influences employee morale. Based on prior research in the human resource field, we predict an interaction between transparency and morale on volunteers.

H3b: Volunteer morale moderates organizational transparency's influence on supporter intentions.

Organizational socialization. Whereas onboarding refers to an organization's process of integrating a new employee into the organization, organizational socialization is more specific and, in our context, refers to facilitating a new volunteer into the social community of the nonprofit organization (Bauer & Erdogan, 2012). Manifestations of successful organizational socialization include healthy and positive social interactions between a volunteer and other members of the organization. They include feeling known by an organization's leadership, staff, and other volunteers. They include feelings of belonging and being accepted (Bauer & Erdogan, 2012).

Given the lack of research on volunteers, we will use prior research on employees from which to draw inferences, thus extending this research to volunteer management. In the human resource management literature, successful organizational socialization has been positively associated with organizational commitment (Bauer & Green, 1998), job satisfaction (Saks et al., 2007), performance (Bauer et al., 2006); and negatively associated with turnover (Fu et al., 2005). Nguyen et al. (2021) found that organizational socialization had a positive influence on employees' proactive behaviors and work engagement.

It is reasonable to believe that organizational socialization would influence volunteers' attitudes and behaviors. We predict that organizational socialization would interact with brand strength's effect on our volunteers' support intentions. We argued for a direct effect of brand strength previously. Since, we predict direct effects on our outcomes from both organizational socialization and brand strength, it is likely that the two constructs, since they both have a positive influence on our outcomes, interact. For example, volunteers' negative perceptions of their organization's socialization efforts would likely negatively affect their attitudes toward the organization (brand attitudes), which would reduce brands strength.

H4a: Organizational socialization moderates brand strength's influence on supporter intentions.

We were unable to identify prior research which examined the relationship between organizational socialization and transparency. However, we think it is reasonable to believe that some relationship does exist. To be effectively socialized into an organization can be expected to enhance organizational trust (Haski-Leventhal & Bargal, 2008). How could one feel a part of an untrustworthy organization? Transparency is a necessary precursor of trust within a nonprofit organization (Helmig & Thaler, 2010). Organizational socialization enhances volunteers' familiarity with the organization, facilitating transparency perceptions. Poor organizational transparency reduces volunteers' feelings of familiarity with the organization. Hence, we predict an interaction effect between organizational socialization and organizational transparency.

H4b: Organizational socialization moderates organizational transparency's influence on supporter intentions.

Training program quality. When volunteers are prepared for service through an excellent training program, positive benefits should be expected. Volunteers' attitudes toward the organization are more positive. Volunteers can be expected to be less frustrated and more successful and, thus, more satisfied with volunteering. Hence, an excellent training program, all other things being equal, should have a positive influence on volunteers' support intentions.

Some volunteers are motivated to give their service to acquire marketable skills and training (Lammers, 1991). Certainly, these volunteers would be dissatisfied if those motivating expectations were unmet. With respect to volunteers with other motives, it is probable that the quality of their organization's training program as they begin their volunteer service would influence their perceptions of the organization's management quality and, hence, their attitudes toward the organization (Gidron, 1983; Murk & Stephan, 1991). Their attitudes toward the organization reduce their brand strength perceptions. Volunteers' perceptions of the quality of their organization's training program influence their attitudes toward the organization and, thus, should interact with brand strength.

H5a: Training program quality moderates brand strength's influence on supporter intentions.

One would expect that an excellent volunteer training program would familiarize the volunteer trainee with the organization. If the training program results in the volunteer becoming more familiar and knowledgeable about the organization, then it seems reasonable to predict that the volunteer would perceive the organization to be more transparent than if a weak or absent

training program left the new volunteer with little knowledge and familiarity of the organization. Hence, volunteers' perceptions of their organizations' training programs should interact with organizational transparency.

H5b: Training program quality moderates organizational transparency's influence on supporter intentions.

Organizational trust. Organizational trust refers to a psychological state comprising the intention to accept vulnerability based upon positive expectations of the organization's intentions or behavior (Möllering et al., 2004; Mühl, 2014). Prior research has found that organizations with higher levels of organizational trust tend to be more efficient, effective, adaptive, and innovative (Shockley-Zalabak et al., 2000). Hence, organization trust should influence volunteers' attitudes, which influences brand strength.

Salas (2008) found that organizational commitment is a predictor of volunteers' intentions to remain which is influenced by volunteers' trust in the organization's mission, leadership, and activities' effectiveness. Bekkers (2012) reported that people with low levels of trust are more likely to quit volunteering. Other research has not found trust to be a predictor of volunteer retention (Washinko, 2022). Windon et al. (2024) argued that the influence of effective communication skills on volunteer retention is mediated through their effect on trust. A. Becker et al. (2020) argued that a lack of trust in the fundraising organization has a negative influence on donation intentions.

We predict that organizational trust interacts with brand strength's influence on supporter intentions. We argue that the positive effects of a high level of brand strength are enhanced when organizational trust is high and reduced when organizational trust is low. Hence, we offer the following hypothesis.

H6a: Organizational trust moderates brand strength's influence on supporter intentions.

It was previously discussed how prior research has consistently reported a relationship between organizational transparency and trust. We, therefore, predict that organizational transparency interacts with organizational trust and offers the following hypothesis.

H6b: Organizational trust moderates organizational transparency's influence on supporter intentions.

Confidence in leadership. Confidence in leadership refers to volunteers' assurance that the organization's supervisory and management team leads the organization and supervises its volunteers in an excellent manner. There is reason to believe that volunteers' confidence in their organization's leadership

influences their retention and support intentions. Senses-Ozyurt and Villicana-Reyna (2016) reported that leader integrity and inclusiveness predicted volunteer retention. Glass (2018) reported that nonprofit leaders who were collaborative, motivating, and good communicators were more effective in retaining volunteers. Ngah et al. (2022) reported that servant leadership influenced volunteer retention through job satisfaction. Based on this prior research, we offer the following hypothesis.

It is likely that volunteers' attitudes toward their organizations' leadership interacts with brand strength. If volunteers have poor attitudes toward their organizations' management, this can be expected to be manifested in lower attitudes toward the organization, which is reflected in lower brand attitude levels and, hence, lower brand strength.

H7a: Confidence in leadership moderates brand strength's influence on supporter intentions.

Transparency is linked to accountability, which refers to the extent to which the organization can be held to its promises (Lloyd, 2005). Being accountable and transparent engenders trust (Putnam, 1993). An organization's relationships with its stakeholders depend on transparency and trust (Lamming et al., 2001). Buell et al. (2021) recommend that in an era of declining trust in government the delivery of government services to the public should be designed in a more transparent manner to foster greater trust in public institutions.

We predict that volunteers' confidence in their organization's leadership interacts with organizational transparency. Organizational transparency influences leadership confidence. Volunteers may be distrustful of management when there is little organizational transparency. A high level of transparency may enhance volunteers' confidence in management. Hence, we offer the following hypothesis.

H7b: Confidence in leadership moderates organizational transparency's influence on supporter intentions.

Organizational pride. This construct refers to an individual's pleasure or satisfaction from having an association with an organization (Helm, 2013). With respect to paid employees, organizational pride has been found to enhance commitment and reduce turnover (Pereira et al., 2021). In a study on employee turnover, Helm (2013), predicted (relying on social identity theory) that the influence on an employer's reputation on employee turnover intentions was mediated by employees' organizational pride and job satisfaction. Groza and Groza (2022) examined influences on episodic event volunteers' intentions to volunteer for the event in the following year. They found

that an organization's reputation influenced episodic volunteers' returning intentions through organizational pride (mediator).

We could not find any prior research which examined the relationship between brand strength and organizational pride. However, we believe a likely interaction effect may exist. If volunteers have low (high) levels of organizational pride, this is likely to negatively (positively) influence volunteers perceive brand attitudes, and thus, brand strength.

H8a: Organizational pride moderates brand strength's influence on supporter intentions.

Organizational transparency engenders trust (Jiang & Luo, 2018). Organizational pride, likewise, may be inversely related to trust in the organization. Organizational pride and organizational transparency likely covary. It is counterintuitive to view the two constructs and unrelated. The positive affect of strong organizational pride would indicate organizational trust, which would indicate organizational transparency. Organizational pride may accentuate the influence of organizational transparency on volunteers' intentions. Conversely, low organizational pride may reduce the positive effects of organizational transparency (Bennis et al., 2008).

H8b: Organizational pride moderates organizational transparency's influence on supporter intentions.

Value congruence. Value congruence refers to individuals' perceptions of the degree to which their values are like those of an organization (Wymer et al., 2021). Since volunteering is a value expressive behavior (Okun et al., 2015), value congruence should be an important type of fit between volunteers and their organizations (Penner, 2000). Volunteering provides individuals with an opportunity to act on their core values, which are often not able to be expressed through paid employment, like redressing social injustice, returning one's good fortune, and reducing suffering and deprivation (Cnaan & Goldberg-Glen, 1991).

Charities' values are manifested in their missions, the types of causes they support, and the people they help (in some cases). Wymer and Rundle-Thiele (2016) reported that people who had feelings of loyalty toward charities felt loyalty toward their charities' missions and the people helped by the charities' work. We predict that when volunteers perceive a close value congruence with their organizations, the value congruence enhances volunteers' perceptions of their organizations' brand strength.

H9a: Value congruence moderates brand strength's influence on supporter intentions.

Organizational transparency and organizational trust are linked. In prior research, value congruence has been found to promote trust in relationships (Lau et al., 2007). A lack of transparency reduces trust in the organization (Farwell et al., 2019). A lack of trust in the organization may reduce the meaningfulness of volunteering (Im & Chung, 2018). Hence, value expressive benefits of volunteering in a low transparency, low trust context may be reduced.

H9b: Value congruence moderates organizational transparency's influence on supporter intentions.

Next, we will describe an empirical study that we conducted to test our hypothesis and conceptual model.

Methods and procedures

Measures

The scale items used to measure the conceptual model's variables are listed in Table 1. In the questionnaire, respondents were presented with the scale items as Likert statements and asked to circle the response choice that corresponded most closely with their level of agreement with the statement. The antecedent, mediator, and moderators were measured with seven-point scales, from 1 = strongly disagree to 7 = strongly agree). The single-item outcome variables were measured with seven-point scales, from 1 = very unlikely to 7 = very likely).

Participants and procedures

Since we were interested volunteers' retention and support intentions, we sought to recruit a sample of active volunteers. We wanted respondent volunteers to come from a variety of organizations and locations. We asked nonprofit organizations to participate in our study by asking their volunteers to complete an online questionnaire. Over 200 nonprofit organizations across Canada were contacted between August and November 2023. Ethics review board anonymity requirements were such that we were unable to identify all the organizations that participated as well as individual volunteers completing our online questionnaire. Some of the nonprofit organizations we contacted were umbrella organizations and some organizations asked their peer organizations to participate, so the exact number and profile of participating organizations is not known. This procedure resulted in 631 completed questionnaires.

Table 1. Measurement scales.

Brand strength (Wymer et al., 2016)	<i>Brand Familiarity</i> • I am knowledgeable about my organization's activities. • I can describe my organization to others. • I have a good understanding of what my organization has done in the past. <i>Brand Remarkability</i> • No organization is better than my organization at doing what it does. • My organization really stands apart as being exceptional. • My organization stands out in comparison to others. <i>Brand Attitudes</i> • I have positive thoughts when I think of my organization. • I like my organization. • I have a positive impression about my organization.
Organizational transparency (adapted from Schnackenberg et al., 2021)	• I am confident that my organization openly shares information about itself and operations. • I am confident that my organization openly shares information about how its decisions are made. • I am confident that my organization openly shares information about its priorities.
Volunteer morale (adapted from Arunchand & Ramanathan, 2013)	• I have a positive impression of the organization's leadership. • I believe that my organization is exceptional. • The volunteers and staff in the organization are friendly.
Organization socialization (adapted from Chao et al., 1994)	• There is a healthy level of social interaction between me and the rest of my organization. • The leadership, staff, and volunteers of my organization know me.
Training program quality (adapted from Sahinidis & Bouris, 2008)	• My organization makes me feel like I belong. • When I first became a volunteer, my organization made sure that I knew what I was supposed to do before I began to perform my volunteer tasks. • When I first became a volunteer, my organization showed me how to perform my volunteer tasks. • When I first became a volunteer, my organization made sure that I was comfortable in performing my volunteer tasks before assigning me tasks to do on my own.
Organizational trust (adapted from McKnight & Chervany, 2000)	• My organization is reliable. • My organization is honest. • My organization is managed with integrity.
Confidence in leadership (adapted from Oyinlade, 2006)	• My organization's leadership is highly skilled. • My organization's leadership is highly effective. • My organization's leadership motivates us to perform at higher levels.
Organizational pride (adapted from Groza & Groza, 2022; Helm, 2013)	• I get a sense of satisfaction from being a member of this organization. • I am pleased to tell others that I volunteer for this organization. • I am pleased to identify myself personally with this organization.
Value congruence (adapted from Wymer et al., 2021)	• My organization and I share important values. • The mission of my organization represents values that are important to me. • Supporting the work of my organization allows me to express my values.
1 year retention intentions	How likely are you to continue volunteering for this organization another year?
5-year retention intentions	How likely are you to continue volunteering for this organization for the next five years?
Donation intentions	How likely are you to donate to this organization in the coming year?
Bequest intentions	How likely are you to leave a bequest to this organization in your will?
Volunteer recruitment intentions	How likely are you to encourage others to volunteer for this organization?
Word-of-mouth intentions	How likely are you to make favorable comments to others about this organization?

Sample

In total, 631 participants enrolled in this study. We examined potential outliers and, as a result, 32 cases indicated as severe outliers in multiple items of questionnaire were excluded. We proceed with the analysis with final sample size $N = 599$. Descriptive analysis of the sample revealed sample age range from 18 to 92, with mean age of 57.64 years. Related to gender, the majority were females, (78.1%), while 1.3% were declared as others. Average years of education were 16.1, indicating at least high school diploma of participants. Related to volunteer behavior, participants spend in average 13.24 h (monthly), with average number of weeks since last volunteered 5.38, and frequency of monthly volunteering 4.41 times.

Analysis

We used variance-based partial least squares structural equation modeling (PLS-SEM) with SmartPLS 4.0 software (Ringle et al., 2022). This approach is appropriate for models with single and multi-item constructs (Chin, 2010), non-normally distributed data, and examination of complex model of factors influencing volunteer support intentions with primarily explanatory purpose (source). The minimal sample size was estimated with Inverse square root method (Kock & Hadaya, 2018) on a level of a minimal expected path of 0.15, indicating sample size adequacy (599 cases obtained compared to 276 needed). No missing values were determined in items related to constructs, only in demographic characteristics of respondents. Since no control variables were used in the model, we treated missing demographic data as missing in the dataset. Nonparametric percentile bootstrapping method was used with 599 cases and 10,000 sub-samples (J. M. Becker et al., 2023).

Common method bias was checked following the procedure proposed by Podsakoff et al. (2003) in two phases. First, we ensure temporal, proximal and psychological separation of predictor and criterion variables in our questionnaire. Next, we used single common method factor approach with Harman's single factor (Kock, 2015) as predictor and criterion variables could not be obtained from different sources but can be measured in different context and source of method bias cannot be identified, as recommended by Podsakoff et al. (2003). The first factor accounted for 45.14% with unrotated principal component analysis extraction method (below the threshold of 50% (Kock, 2020)).

Variance inflation factors (VIF) for all reflective lower order constructs were examined for inner model expressing values below the cutoff value of 3.3 (Kock, 2015) for all items representing support intentions except for confidence in leadership (CL, VIF = 3.67) and volunteer morale (VM, VIF = 3.491).

Since the proposed model is reflective, we did not examine outer model VIFs. Due to the high VIF values, that can cause potential collinearity issues, CL and VM constructs were excluded from further analysis.

In the next step, we estimated measurement model in two phases, first for lower order, and then for higher order construct measurement model. We followed procedure as proposed by Hair et al. (2019). For measurement model, we used constructs' internal consistency, reliability, and convergent validity. For estimation of structural model, we used explanatory power, out-of-sample predictive power (R2, Q2, PLSpredict) and significance and relevance of the path coefficients.

Lower order measurement model validation

Validity and reliability analysis for the lower order measurement model indicate good fit. Factor loadings and Cronbach alphas are well above the threshold of .70 (Hair et al., 2019) (all above .80). Composite reliability scores range from .828 to .944, which is within suggested range from .70 to .95 (Hair et al., 2014). The average variance extracted (AVE) is also above the cutoff of .50, confirming convergent validity (Hair et al., 2019). All indicators' loadings are also higher for own construct than on others.

Discriminant validity was confirmed, as presented in Table 2. All constructs square root of AVE is higher than the correlation with other constructs (Fornell-Larcker criterion) and HTMT ratio of correlation is below .90 (Chin, 2010; Henseler et al., 2015).

Higher order measurement model validation

We conceptualize a hierarchical component model of brand strength (BS) consisting of three reflective lower-order constructs, namely, brand remarkability (BR), brand familiarity (BF) and brand attitude (BA). With a disjoint two-stage

Table 2. Discriminant validity of lower order constructs.

	BA	BF	BR	OP	OR	OS	OT	TP	VC
BA	0.948	0.522	0.699	0.617	0.549	0.575	0.661	0.373	0.608
BF	0.462	0.862	0.456	0.41	0.376	0.469	0.458	0.307	0.561
BR	0.654	0.397	0.926	0.42	0.489	0.437	0.514	0.304	0.474
OP	0.576	0.36	0.389	0.932	0.423	0.472	0.554	0.359	0.76
OR	0.51	0.326	0.451	0.39	0.926	0.677	0.693	0.48	0.475
OS	0.532	0.402	0.4	0.432	0.615	0.908	0.682	0.543	0.505
OT	0.608	0.394	0.469	0.504	0.628	0.614	0.91	0.487	0.639
TP	0.344	0.265	0.277	0.329	0.439	0.491	0.439	0.919	0.473
VC	0.541	0.468	0.419	0.671	0.417	0.442	0.554	0.415	0.868

Square root of AVE, in bold and gray-diagonal elements; HTMT values in italics above diagonal, latent variable correlation matrix below diagonal.

approach, higher order reflective-reflective construct of brand strength was checked, generating latent variable scores for BR, BF and BA, using them as indicators for brand strength as higher order constructs (Sarstedt et al., 2019). Factor loadings (BR = .84, BF = .712, BA = .896) are above the threshold of .50; CA and composite reliability (CA = .753; CR = .791) are above the threshold of .70; and average variance extracted (AVE=.671) is also above the threshold of .50 (Hair et al., 2020). The discriminant validity of BS as a higher-order construct was also confirmed as the HTMT ratio is below .90 (Henseler et al., 2015), and the square root of AVE for BS (in bold) is higher than the correlation with all other constructs as presented in Table 3.

Mediation analysis

Our proposed model predicts partial mediation of Organizational transparency (OR) on six Supporter intention items and direct influence of Brand strengths (BS) on Supporter intentions, so both paths were included in the model. Effects were examined with bootstrapping technique and 10.000 subsamples. Brand strength influences Organizational transparency ($\beta = .533$, $t = 15.937$, $p = .000$), and Organizational transparency influences two out of six supporter intentions (DI: $\beta = .219$, $t = 3.402$, $p = .001$; BI: $\beta = .172$, $t = 2.877$, $p = .004$). Brand strength directly influences all six supporter intentions, as presented in Table 4. Based on these results, we conclude that there is complementary partial mediation of organizational transparency in the relationship between Brand strength and Donation and Bequest intentions.

Moderation analysis

From theoretically conceptualized seven moderators, five remain in the model. We conceptualized that all moderators are moderating both direct and indirect effect of brand Strength on Supporter intentions (see Figure 1). In total, 12 moderation effects were analyzed on six Supporter intentions constructs. We used moderators from initial conceptualization of the proposed model as suggested by Andersson et al. (2020). Results indicate four significant moderation effect as presented in Table 4.

Table 3. Discriminant validity of higher order reflective-reflective construct.

HTMT ratio								
	BS	OP	OR	OS	OT	TP	VC	VM
BS		0.647	0.632	0.661	0.73	0.438	0.732	0.803
Fornell-Larcker criterion								
BS	0.819	0.552	0.533	0.55	0.61	0.364	0.583	0.655

Interestingly, neither one of proposed moderators moderates direct relationship between Brand strength and Supporter intentions. A few moderating effects were determined in relationship between organizational transparency (OR) and supporter intentions. Organizational socialization (OS) is strengthening relationship between OR and 5 years retention intention (VR5) (OS x OR $\rightarrow$ VR5; $\beta = .12$, $p = .027$). Training program quality (TP) strengthens relationship between OR and recruitment intention (REC) (TP x OR $\rightarrow$ REC; $\beta = .122$, $p = .03$), and 1-year retention intentions (VR1) (TP x OR $\rightarrow$ VR1; $\beta = .145$, $p = .015$). Finally, Volunteer morale also strengthens the relationship between OR and VR1 (VM x OR $\rightarrow$ VR1; $\beta = .173$, $p = .03$).

Structural model evaluation

Structural model evaluation, including decision for acceptance/rejection of proposed hypotheses is presented in [Table 4](#).

The analysis confirmed direct effect of brand strength on six supporter intentions, with the highest path coefficient for 5-year retention intentions (VR5 = .246) and the lowest for donation intentions (DI = .13). Hypothesized partial mediation effects were confirmed as complementary partial mediation of organizational transparency in relationship between brand strength and bequest intentions (specific indirect effects BS $\rightarrow$ OR $\rightarrow$ BI, $\beta = .092$) and donation intentions (specific indirect effects BS $\rightarrow$ OR $\rightarrow$ DI, $\beta = .117$). Although hypothesized, moderation effects of proposed constructs were not determined for direct relationship between brand strength and supporter intentions. Moderation effects related to indirect relationships (organizational transparency and supporter intentions) are confirmed only for three proposed moderators and for one or two specific intentions (VM x OR $\rightarrow$ VR1, $\beta = .173$; OS x OR $\rightarrow$ VR5, $\beta = .12$; TP x OR $\rightarrow$ REC, $\beta = .122$; TP x OR $\rightarrow$ VR1, $\beta = .145$).

Finally, we included age as a control variable for six supporter intentions. The results show a small but significant positive impact of Age on VR 5 ($\beta = .106$, $t = 2.289$, $p = .011$) and negative impact on REC ($\beta = -.082$, $t = 2.232$, $p = .013$). No significant impact of age on other outcome variables was found. The strength and significance of the other paths in the model did not change with inclusion of control variable.

In [Figure 2](#), we present model with significant paths. We present direct effects with solid lines and standardized path coefficients left intended in the supporter intentions rectangle. For confirmed mediation effects we also use solid lines with standardized path coefficients noted above the line. Significant moderation effects are presented with dotted lines with adjoining path coefficients.

Table 4. Structural model analysis and hypotheses testing.

Hypotheses	Relationship	Path coefficient/ β	SE	t value	p value	BCCI 5%-95% (one-tailed test)	f ² values	Decision
Direct effect								
H1 a	BS $\rightarrow$ BI	0.172	0.059	2.911	0.002	0.075	0.013	Supported
H1 b	BS $\rightarrow$ DI	0.13	0.066	1.971	0.024	0.024	0.007	Supported
H1 c	BS $\rightarrow$ REC	0.162	0.06	2.683	0.004	0.066	0.013	Supported
H1 d	BS $\rightarrow$ WOM	0.198	0.063	3.156	0.001	0.091	0.029	Supported
H1 e	BS $\rightarrow$ VR1	0.192	0.071	2.686	0.004	0.07	0.018	Supported
H1 f	BS $\rightarrow$ VR5	0.246	0.064	3.849	0	0.137	0.028	Supported
Mediation analysis								
Hypotheses	Relationship	Path coefficient/ β	SE	t value	p value	BCCI 5%-95% (one-tailed test)	f ² values	Decision
H2 a	BS $\rightarrow$ OR $\rightarrow$ BI	0.092	0.033	2.783	0.003	0.039	0.147	Supported
H2 b	BS $\rightarrow$ OR $\rightarrow$ DI	0.117	0.035	3.335	0.000	0.063	0.179	Supported
H2 c	BS $\rightarrow$ OR $\rightarrow$ REC	0.045	0.035	1.286	0.099	-0.009	0.108	Not supported
H2 d	BS $\rightarrow$ OR $\rightarrow$ WOM	0.034	0.034	0.987	0.162	-0.023	0.089	Not supported
H2 e	BS $\rightarrow$ OR $\rightarrow$ VR1	0	0.041	0.001	0.500	-0.065	0.071	Not supported
H2 f	BS $\rightarrow$ OR $\rightarrow$ VR5	-0.005	0.037	0.126	0.450	-0.062	0.059	Not supported
Moderation analysis								
Hypotheses	Relationship	Path coefficient/ β	SE	t value	p value	BCCI 5%-95% (one-tailed test)	f ² values	Decision
H3 A a	VM x BS $\rightarrow$ BI	0.027	0.062	0.437	0.331	-0.073	0	Not supported
H3 A b	VM x BS $\rightarrow$ DI	0.043	0.069	0.622	0.267	-0.07	0.001	Not supported
H3 A c	VM x BS $\rightarrow$ REC	-0.075	0.076	0.988	0.162	-0.203	0.003	Not supported
H3 A d	VM x BS $\rightarrow$ WOM	-0.098	0.075	1.311	0.095	-0.225	0.007	Not supported
H3 A e	VM x BS $\rightarrow$ VR1	-0.061	0.089	0.681	0.248	-0.211	0.002	Not supported
H3 A f	VM x BS $\rightarrow$ VR5	-0.011	0.073	0.146	0.442	-0.127	0	Not supported
H3 B a	VM x OR $\rightarrow$ BI	0.013	0.061	0.21	0.417	-0.09	0	Not supported
H3 B b	VM x OR $\rightarrow$ DI	-0.003	0.071	0.041	0.484	-0.117	0	Not supported
H3 B c	VM x OR $\rightarrow$ REC	0.094	0.069	1.358	0.087	-0.015	0.004	Not supported
H3 B d	VM x OR $\rightarrow$ WOM	0.01	0.075	0.135	0.446	-0.113	0	Not supported
H3 B e	VM x OR $\rightarrow$ VR1	0.173	0.079	2.189	0.014	0.052	0.015	Supported
H3 B f	VM x OR $\rightarrow$ VR5	0.02	0.068	0.293	0.385	-0.091	0	Not supported
H4 A a	OS x BS $\rightarrow$ BI	0.05	0.052	0.955	0.17	-0.034	0.001	Not supported
H4 A b	OS x BS $\rightarrow$ DI	0.065	0.059	1.099	0.136	-0.03	0.002	Not supported
H4 A c	OS x BS $\rightarrow$ REC	0.04	0.069	0.579	0.281	-0.065	0.001	Not supported

(Continued)

Table 4. (Continued).

Hypotheses	Relationship	Path coefficient/ β	SE	t value	p value	BCCI 5%-95% (one-tailed test)	f ² values	Decision
H4 A d	OS x BS -> WOM	0.017	0.068	0.247	0.402	-0.086	0	Not supported
H4 A e	OS x BS -> VR1	-0.044	0.067	0.656	0.256	-0.146	0.001	Not supported
H4 A f	OS x BS -> VR5	-0.033	0.055	0.598	0.275	-0.113	0.001	Not supported
H4 B a	OS x OR -> BI	-0.043	0.052	0.831	0.203	-0.133	0.001	Not supported
H4 B b	OS x OR -> DI	0.031	0.06	0.521	0.301	-0.072	0.001	Not supported
H4 B c	OS x OR -> REC	-0.029	0.057	0.5	0.308	-0.127	0	Not supported
H4 B d	OS x OR -> WOM	0.053	0.06	0.885	0.188	-0.05	0.002	Not supported
H4 B e	OS x OR -> VR1	-0.054	0.063	0.851	0.197	-0.165	0.002	Not supported
H4 B f	OS x OR -> VR5	0.12	0.055	2.192	0.014	0.029	0.008	Supported
H5 A a	TP x BS -> BI	0.037	0.038	0.976	0.165	-0.032	0.001	Not supported
H5 A b	TP x BS -> DI	0.004	0.048	0.092	0.463	-0.079	0	Not supported
H5 A c	TP x BS -> REC	-0.056	0.063	0.882	0.189	-0.156	0.003	Not supported
H5 A d	TP x BS -> WOM	-0.077	0.056	1.375	0.085	-0.16	0.008	Not supported
H5 A e	TP x BS -> VR1	-0.104	0.067	1.54	0.062	-0.203	0.01	Not supported
H5 A f	TP x BS -> VR5	-0.031	0.055	0.573	0.283	-0.115	0.001	Not supported
H5 B a	TP x OR -> BI	-0.011	0.042	0.264	0.396	-0.077	0	Not supported
H5 B b	TP x OR -> DI	-0.042	0.049	0.861	0.195	-0.117	0.001	Not supported
H5 B c	TP x OR -> REC	0.122	0.057	2.129	0.017	0.033	0.013	Supported
H5 B d	TP x OR -> WOM	0.063	0.048	1.329	0.092	-0.013	0.005	Not supported
H5 B e	TP x OR -> VR1	0.145	0.06	2.411	0.008	0.048	0.018	Supported
H5 B f	TP x OR -> VR5	0.07	0.047	1.499	0.067	-0.003	0.004	Not supported
H6 A a	OT x BS -> BI	-0.058	0.063	0.927	0.177	-0.164	0.002	Not supported
H6 A b	OT x BS -> DI	-0.078	0.059	1.314	0.094	-0.178	0.003	Not supported
H6 A c	OT x BS -> REC	0.008	0.078	0.103	0.459	-0.106	0	Not supported
H6 A d	OT x BS -> WOM	0.099	0.081	1.224	0.11	-0.028	0.008	Not supported
H6 A e	OT x BS -> VR1	0.081	0.077	1.054	0.146	-0.033	0.004	Not supported
H6 A f	OT x BS -> VR5	0.023	0.066	0.35	0.363	-0.08	0	Not supported
H6 B a	OT x OR -> BI	0.091	0.059	1.535	0.062	0.005	0.004	Not supported
H6 B b	OT x OR -> DI	-0.003	0.063	0.048	0.481	-0.1	0	Not supported
H6 B c	OT x OR -> REC	-0.06	0.088	0.679	0.249	-0.213	0.002	Not supported
H6 B d	OT x OR -> WOM	-0.134	0.083	1.612	0.053	-0.28	0.014	Not supported
H6 B e	OT x OR -> VR1	-0.068	0.072	0.94	0.174	-0.19	0.002	Not supported
H6 B f	OT x OR -> VR5	-0.047	0.061	0.775	0.219	-0.152	0.001	Not supported
H7 A	CL x BS -> Supp.int							Excluded
H7 B	CL x OR -> Supp.int							Excluded
H8 A	OP x BS -> Supp.int							Excluded

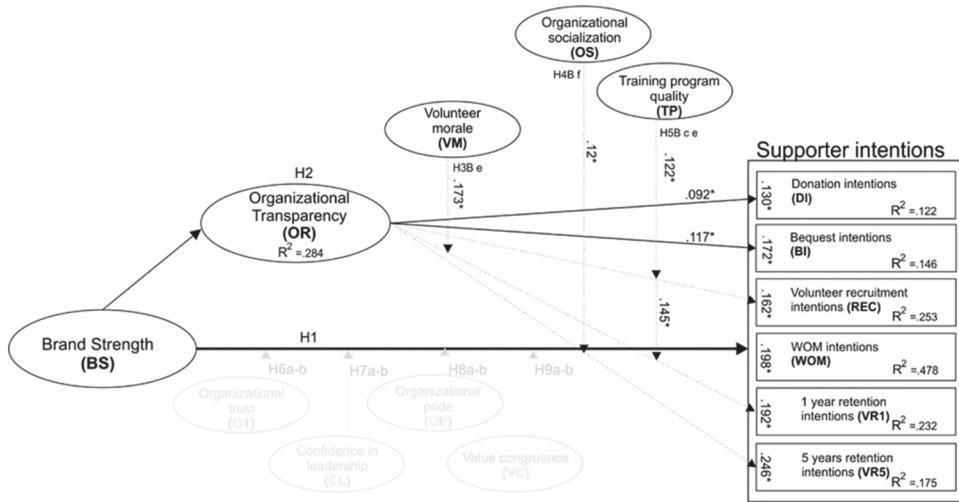
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Table 4. (Continued).

Hypotheses	Relationship	Path coefficient/ β	SE	t value	p value	BCCI 5%-95% (one-tailed test)	f ² values	Decision
H8 B	OP x OR -> Supp.int							Excluded
H9 A a	VC x BS -> BI	-0.05	0.05	0.989	0.161	-0.135	0.002	Not supported
H9 A b	VC x BS -> DI	-0.047	0.055	0.841	0.2	-0.14	0.001	Not supported
H9 A c	VC x BS -> REC	0.002	0.072	0.034	0.486	-0.121	0	Not supported
H9 A d	VC x BS -> WOM	-0.109	0.068	1.597	0.055	-0.223	0.013	Not supported
H9 A e	VC x BS -> VR1	-0.067	0.069	0.969	0.166	-0.179	0.003	Not supported
H9 A f	VC x BS -> VR5	-0.039	0.054	0.726	0.234	-0.126	0.001	Not supported
H9 B a	VC x OR -> BI	0.038	0.05	0.763	0.223	-0.043	0.001	Not supported
H9 B b	VC x OR -> DI	0.035	0.06	0.573	0.283	-0.068	0.001	Not supported
H9 B c	VC x OR -> REC	-0.02	0.064	0.319	0.375	-0.126	0	Not supported
H9 B d	VC x OR -> WOM	0.059	0.06	0.994	0.16	-0.047	0.004	Not supported
H9 B e	VC x OR -> VR1	0.002	0.053	0.042	0.483	-0.079	0	Not supported
H9 B f	VC x OR -> VR5	-0.031	0.047	0.671	0.251	-0.108	0.001	Not supported

Table 5. Predictive power and validity.

	R ²	Q ² predict	PLS-SEM_RMSE	LM_RMSE
BI	0.146	0.089	1.865	1.862
DI	0.122	0.052	2.124	2.107
REC	0.253	0.187	1.053	1.05
VR1	0.232	0.139	1.042	1.047
VR5	0.175	0.109	1.481	1.486
WOM	0.478	0.409	0.676	0.672
OR1			1.276	1.064
OR2			1.392	1.21
OR3			1.271	1.134
OR	0.284	0.28		

**Figure 2.** Structural model with significant paths.

Structural model validation

We validated our structural model by analyzing the coefficient of determination (R^2), redundancy measure (Q^2) and path coefficients significance (Sarstedt et al., 2022). We used PLSpredict procedure (Shmueli et al., 2019) for out-of-sample predictive power analysis to determine ability of proposed model to predict same relationships with new observations (Hair & Sarstedt, 2021).

The R^2 values for endogenous constructs for supporter intentions ($BI = .146$; $DI = .122$; $REC = .253$; $WOM = .478$; $VR1 = .232$; $VR5 = .175$) indicate weak to moderate influence. The R^2 value for OR (.284) also indicate weak influence based on Hair et al. (2014) recommendations for R^2 values (0.75 substantial, 0.50 moderate, and 0.25 weak influence).

Q^2 values derived from PLSpredict software feature were used for estimation of predictive relevance of the proposed model for supporter intentions

(Hair et al., 2019). Since Q^2 values were higher than 0 for all supporter intentions (ranging from .089 to .409) the predictive relevance of the model was confirmed.

In the final step, presented in Table 5, PLS-SEM RMSE values were compared with the naïve benchmark (LM RMSE) (Shmueli et al., 2019), indicating lower values of PLS-RMSE compared to naïve LM benchmark for two out of six supporter intentions (VR1, VR5), therefore, the minority. These results indicate low predictive power of the model.

Discussion

The scientific and practical relevance of this study is that it adds to our knowledge on construct relationships that influence volunteers' retention intentions and intentions to support their organizations in additional ways. Researchers can use our discoveries to further our understanding of these phenomena. Managers can use our discoveries to inform their managerial practices to more effectively retain their volunteers and deepen their commitment.

This study finds that brand strength has a significant influence on all our outcome variables. Prior research on consumer behavior for commercial marketing has found many benefits for strong brands. Consumers have more favorable attribute and benefit perceptions and an overall preference for strong brands. Consumers are more willing to pay a price premium for strong brands (Hoeffler & Keller, 2003).

Grau and Kleiser (2012) argue that a strong brand can provide benefits to nonprofit organizations, including greater awareness for the cause, greater loyalty among donors and volunteers, and greater differentiation among competitors. Our findings support the relationship between brand strength and volunteer retention and commitment. It may be worthwhile for nonprofit managers to view increasing their organization's brand strength as a strategic priority.

Effective volunteer retention has long been viewed as resulting from effective volunteer supervision, leadership, and management (Hager & Brudney, 2004; Studer, 2016). It would be interesting for a future study to examine the mediation influence of brand strength in the relationship between volunteer supervision practices and volunteer retention and commitment.

Hoeffler and Keller (2003) report that strong brands enjoy favorable benefits with respect to consumer advertising. They claim that consumers pay greater attention, react more positively, and retain more information for strong brands. Future research on the audience effects of brand strength in marketing communications for nonprofit brands would enhance our knowledge in this area.

It is interesting to note that the influence of brand strength on our financial support intentions (donation and bequest intentions) was partially mediated through organizational transparency. Supporting one's organization through monetary gifts seems to be influenced by additional factors. Perhaps when it comes to donating money, supporters may be more risk adverse than when supporting an organization in other ways. Prior research has shown that trust in a charity is influenced by its perceived transparency (Furneaux & Wymer, 2015; Wymer et al., 2021). Our study finds that a portion of brand strength's influence on monetary support intentions is channeled through its influence on transparency. Future research would contribute to our knowledge in this area by investigating the relationship among brand strength, trust, transparency, and donation intentions.

The influence of transparency on volunteers' support intentions extended beyond monetary support when transparency interacted with other factors. For example, volunteer morale interacted with transparency to influence one-year retention intentions. Training program quality interacted with transparency to influence one-year retention intentions and volunteers' intentions to help their organizations' volunteer recruitment efforts. Organizational socialization interacted with transparency to influence five-year retention intentions. These findings remind us that the influence of factors on our outcome variables can be transmitted through interaction effects.

As age as control variable only has a significant impact on two of the six supporters' intentions which are of poor strength, it can be concluded that age has no real influence on the outcome variables. For example, bequest intentions could be considered an outcome that is more pronounced in older people. The beliefs and attitudes of the general population (including volunteers) change due to changes in the environment, regardless of age. Digital literacy and the variety of sources for information via digital channels have an impact on everyone. In this way, the impact of age (e.g. life experience and wisdom) is minimized, as many things can be (pseudo) experienced via virtual channels.

We examined a comparatively complex model. Our model included six outcome variables, one moderator, and seven moderators. While parsimonious models are easier to interpret and less prone to statistical anomalies, a more complex model may allow the stronger influences to emerge in a context more closely approximating the dynamic environment in which volunteering takes place. It is valuable to examine a complex model that reflects the multiple influences at play in a real setting rather than testing a simple model that does not allow for the multiple influences and interactions that are present on volunteers in their actual experience.

There is usually some balance to be made between internal validity and external validity when developing a research design. The potential increase in Type I error, while imperfect, was addressed in two ways. First, when multiple

variables are examined in a single test as part of a PLS model, the probability of a Type I error does not increase to the extent it would if each variable's significance was tested individually. For example, if four factors are included in an ANOVA test, since the means are being tested at the same time the probability of a Type I error does not increase as it would if we did four separate t-tests. Second, the p-values for our significant results far below the 0.05 significance threshold, closer to 0.01.

It is interesting to note that a more complex model has fewer degrees of freedom than a simple model with fewer variables. As the degrees of freedom decrease, it is more difficult to achieve statistical significance. Hence, while in total it appears that there are comparatively few significant relationships in our conceptual model, those significant relationships have substantial comparative importance and are both theoretically and managerially valuable.

Conventional wisdom assumes volunteers may support their organization in additional ways. Our study enriches our understanding of influences on volunteers' retention intentions as well as other support intentions. The importance of brand strength is amplified when its effects on an array of support intentions are better understood.

Managerial implications

Effective volunteer management is manifested in high volunteer retention rates and strong volunteer organizational support. However, as our findings show, influences on volunteer retention and other support are not limited to effective supervision. Indeed, brand strength and organizational transparency are the responsibility of an organization's leadership at the executive and board levels. Volunteer supervision does not occur in isolation but within the context of an organization's culture and norms. Hence, responsibility for effective volunteer management is distributed across the organization.

Our findings support the argument that an organization that is a strong brand enjoys better outcomes from its marketing activities. All other things being equal, a nonprofit organization that is a stronger brand should experience higher volunteer retention rates and greater volunteer commitment than an organization that is a weaker brand. Managing an organization in such a manner that inspires prospective supporters to perceive it as excellent, exceptional, and superior is foundational. Marketing an organization in such a manner that it becomes well known and the organization's superiority is established is required as well.

It is interesting to note that perceived organizational transparency mediates the influence of brand strength on volunteers' donation and bequest intentions. This finding is consistent with prior research on donors that finds transparency a significant influence (Furneaux & Wymer, 2015). When

considering a bequest or donation, individuals appear to be influenced by the perceived transparency of the organization. Perhaps transparency is related to trust and potential donor risk. Further research might aid our understanding of these relationships.

Future research

Previously, in our literature review, we cited prior studies which found a relationship between an organization's reputation and donation intentions. Whereas reputation is a somewhat nebulous construct, brand strength is more clearly conceptualized and measured (Wymer et al., 2016). It may be more strategically advantageous to emphasize increasing brand strength as a managerial focus rather than reputation. Brand strength may prove to be an important metric for managerial or marketing effectiveness. An increase in brand strength may prove to be a leading indicator of positive benefits to the organization.

As discussed in the introduction, brand-related research for nonprofit organizations is not well developed. Conceiving of an organization as a brand as latent psychological construct in the minds of stakeholder groups may be quite useful in helping the organization to more effectively attract and retain support from target audiences. Whether trying to increase volunteer retention and commitment or trying to stimulate greater support from other groups, increasing brand strength provides a strategic focus. Future research is needed to compare increasing brand strength with other management strategies. A brand management orientation is likely to have greater relevance for organizations that have a greater dependence on attracting and retaining support from individuals in a competitive environment.

Future research is needed to better understand the context in which brand strength is differentially beneficial to organizations. Additionally, managers need to understand how they can increase the brand strength of their organizations. What are antecedents to brand strength and its dimensions? Discovering brand strength antecedents that have a strong influence would add to our knowledge in this area as well as provide practical utility for managers.

Our results showing some differential influences on monetary support intention are interesting and informative. Future research is needed to better understand supporter behavior dynamics that distinguish monetary support decisions from volunteering support decisions.

Limitations

All scholarly inquiries have limitations. Although we attempted to obtain a sample of volunteers from a variety of organizations across Canada, respondents were not randomly selected from the global population of volunteers. Hence, generalization of these findings will need to be supported through future research. The scope of our study was examining the influences of constructs in our model on volunteers. We do not generalize our findings to populations of nonvolunteers.

Furthermore, we tested a complex model which necessitated measurement model evaluation and structural model analysis through advanced techniques. Our model contained factors and variables which were generally latent psychological constructs, which are unable to be perfectly measured. Hence, our findings are limited to the scope of our investigation, the construct relationships we examined, and the precision of our measures.

Disclosure statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the author(s).

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Data availability statement

This study's data will be made publicly available in a repository after article publication.

Human participants

The Research Ethics Board (REB) of the University of Alberta approved this study (Pro00129839).

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